

# Arena UI Art Direction & Design System

*Version 2 – Design System Foundation*

## Vision

The UI should feel like it belongs inside the world.

Players should feel as though every panel, button, action bar, and tooltip was forged by master craftsmen—not rendered by software. The interface is an extension of the player's equipment and discipline.

The visual identity is:

- Dark fantasy
- Rugged
- Handcrafted
- Practical
- Readable
- Timeless

Avoid excessive ornamentation, glowing magic, or gothic excess. The interface should support gameplay rather than compete with it.

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## Core Principles

### 1. Readability First

Arena is an action game.

Combat readability is always more important than decoration.

Visual hierarchy should naturally draw the player's attention toward:

- gameplay
- loot
- abilities
- health
- resources

The UI exists to frame information—not become the information.

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## 2. Crafted, Not Manufactured

Everything should appear to have been built by exceptional craftsmen.

Materials:

- forged iron
- tempered steel
- bronze
- brass
- worn leather
- dark wood (used sparingly)

Surfaces should include subtle:

- hammer marks
- scratches
- softened edges
- worn corners
- age

The interface should feel maintained—not pristine and not ruined.

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## 3. Restrained Ornament

Decoration belongs where it does not interfere with functionality.

Primary locations:

- corners
- end caps
- medallions
- brackets
- decorative plates

Stretchable surfaces remain visually calm.

Avoid:

- oversized runes
- giant gems
- spikes everywhere
- excessive filigree
- dramatic magical effects

The player should notice the equipment—not the border around it.

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## 4. Cohesive Materials

Every component should feel like it came from the same civilization.

Primary palette:

- charcoal
- forged steel
- gunmetal
- brass
- ember gold

Gameplay colors are reserved for gameplay.

Examples:

- red = danger
- green = poison/healing
- blue = frost/mana
- purple = arcane
- orange = legendary

Color should communicate mechanics rather than decoration.

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## One Blacksmith

Every UI component should look as though it was created by the same guild of craftsmen.

Different components serve different purposes.

They are not different themes.

They are different tools.

A tooltip should not look identical to an inventory window.

But both should clearly belong to the same world.

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## Frame Hierarchy

The interface is built from a hierarchy of frame families.

Each serves a different role while sharing a common visual language.

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## Hero Frame

Purpose:

Major windows.

Examples:

- Inventory
- Character
- Spellbook
- Merchant
- Crafting
- Talents

Characteristics:

- substantial
- forged
- architectural
- visually important

This frame establishes the identity of Arena.

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## Standard Frame

Purpose:

Panels within larger windows.

Examples:

- equipment panel
- statistics
- inventory sections
- minimap container
- spell lists

Characteristics:

- thinner rails
- lighter construction

- fewer decorative elements

Feels related to the Hero Frame without competing with it.

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## Tooltip Frame

Purpose:

Information.

Examples:

- item tooltips
- spell descriptions
- NPC dialogue
- floating information panels

Characteristics:

- thin
- restrained
- elegant
- almost invisible

The tooltip should frame information rather than draw attention to itself.

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## Modular Construction

The UI is assembled from reusable components.

Do not think in terms of large finished textures.

Think in terms of reusable craftsmanship.

The foundation library consists of:

- Hero corner
- Hero horizontal rail
- Hero vertical rail
- Window fill
- Header plate
- Button
- Divider

Larger windows are compositions of these elements.

New UI should be assembled—not redrawn.

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## Window Fill

The fill provides atmosphere without distraction.

Characteristics:

- dark leather
- subtle steel beneath
- gentle wear
- low visual noise
- calm center

The center is intentionally quiet because it stretches.

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## Header Plate

The header plate is one of Arena's defining motifs.

Characteristics:

- embossed leather
- forged steel
- brass trim
- symmetrical construction

Nearly every major window should use it.

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## Buttons

Buttons should feel physical.

Characteristics:

- forged steel
- tactile bevels
- restrained wear

The authored artwork remains largely neutral.

Gameplay states are expressed through runtime tinting.

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## Inventory System

The inventory should resemble crafted storage rather than floating boxes.

The connected grid reinforces the feeling of a single forged object.

Construction:

- shared lattice
- heavy outer rim
- recessed wells

Item rarity is communicated through an interior glow rather than colored borders.

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## Discipline Language

Arena is defined by combat disciplines rather than classes.

The UI should subtly acknowledge the player's current discipline.

This is achieved through craftsmanship—not color.

Only a small percentage of the UI changes.

Primary candidates:

- action bar end caps
- decorative brackets
- engraved medallions
- corner motifs

The overall layout never changes.

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## Greatsword

Heavy forged plates.

Broad geometry.

Crossguard-inspired forms.

Weight.

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## **Daggers**

Blackened steel.

Leather wrapping.

Slim proportions.

Hooked details.

Precision.

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## **Staff**

Brass fittings.

Engraved rings.

Contained arcane motifs.

Ancient craftsmanship.

Magic is restrained rather than explosive.

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## **Sword & Shield**

Layered steel.

Shield geometry.

Military craftsmanship.

Balanced symmetry.

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## Bow

Iron bound to ash wood.

Leather bindings.

Subtle recurved forms.

Natural craftsmanship.

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Future disciplines should introduce new craftsmanship languages without creating entirely new UI themes.

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## Variants

Variants are expected.

Examples:

- Hero Frame (Heavy)
- Hero Frame (Light)
- Wide Header Plate
- Narrow Header Plate
- Large Inventory Rim
- Small Inventory Rim

Variants inherit from the same design language.

They are evolutions—not replacements.

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## Responsiveness

The UI is designed for flexible layouts.

Rules:

- corners never stretch
- rails repeat or tile cleanly
- centers remain visually calm
- ornament belongs outside stretch regions
- layouts adapt independently from decoration

Artwork should support resolutions from 1280×720 through 4K without losing readability.

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## Emotional Goal

The interface should make players feel:

"I am carrying finely crafted equipment into a dangerous place."

Not:

"I am operating fantasy software."

The UI should quietly reinforce the fantasy through materials, craftsmanship, and restraint.

When players remember Arena, they should remember the feeling of the world—not the interface.